

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality
Loved Into New Life*

January 12th, 2025



*The Barred Spiral Galaxy NGC 1512 captured by the James Webb Space Telescope
Janice Lee (STScI), Thomas Williams (Oxford) and the PHANGS team, via Reuters*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on SERVANT SONG and TALLIS CANON

Paraphrase on INVITATION (Franklin D. Ashdown)

Pastorale Pastoraal (Flor Peeters)

Fugue in G minor, BWV 578 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Prelude in G Major (Georg Rathgeber) and Improvisation

Wie schön leuchtet der Morgenstern (Johann Pachelbel)

Improvisation on Richard Strauss *Also sprach Zarathustra*

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

In this sacred place and time, we believe that we are
children of the God of Unlimited Mystery.

We believe we are enveloped in an unbounded
network of friendships and relationships, filled with grace and goodness.
These gifts are ours in time, and beyond time.

In this place, we believe in the ancient message
that adopting an attitude of love toward life and all that it brings,
will profoundly alter our lives and our universe.

In the shape of this day to come,
together we ask for the power to be continuously thankful,
in our words and in our hearts,
as we give up concern for ourselves and learn to walk
in the freedom of the stars.

In our time together, may the vast mystery beyond comprehension,
fill us with joy and peace and love
this day and always,
as we lift up and open our hearts to the Holy One,
and to each other.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Creating God, Your Fingers Trace

TALLIS' CANON

Creating God, your fingers trace the bold designs of farthest space;
Let sun and moon and stars and light and what lies hidden praise your might.

Sustaining God, your hands uphold earth's myst'ries known or yet untold;
Let water's fragile blend with air, enabling life, proclaim your care.

Redeeming God, your arms embrace all now despised for creed or race;
Let peace, descending like a dove, make known on earth your healing love.
Indwelling God, your gospel claims one family with a billion names;
Let every life be touched by grace until we praise you face to face.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Holy One, on this day as we gather to give thanks for life,
we recognize how much we rely on the mystery that is beyond
our understanding.

Living in this mystery, we are learning to trust what which we will co-create
with you, as we learn to trust ourselves, our friends, our families,
and our very lives, within this universe that continues to unfold.

Help us in this Season of Epiphany,
to release our past to the past,
to release our future to the future,
and to accept our present
as we let go of our cares and fears.

Help us to relinquish our apprehension,
even as we rely on that which we do not understand.
Help us to acknowledge the courage and faith
that you have placed in the deepest parts of our being.

*And then, Holy One, keep us from fear.
Open our hearts to the gifts of this moment,
and bind us to the great unknown as we place our trust
in the One, who has shown us the way.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Break Forth O Beauteous Heavenly Light"
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Schiefelbein

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Within the light of this Epiphany Season,
each day, we seek a loving and forgiving heart,
for without the cultivation of love and forgiveness,
we will never be at peace.

We will learn to live in love, only to the extent that we can truly
become people who can forgive and love ourselves - and each other.

*This morning, we come together trusting in that which is greater
than we can understand.*

May the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

Rev. Schiefelbein

from the Gospel of Matthew, Chapter Three

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Prayer of Our Hearts

Incomprehensible Mystery,
we have been given this day and
an awareness of its colors and sounds.
We receive these and other gifts
too numerous to name and infinitely rare.
For these gifts, we are thankful

We do not know what this year will bring –
life is the great enigma;
life is the great good;
and we will expect goodness from this day,
and from all the days to come.

At all times, and at this time
we are grateful to participate in the great Mystery.
We acknowledge our contingent nature.
We humble ourselves before that which
we do not understand.

When we consider the vast reaches of the cosmos,
the incomprehensible forces at work in each moment,
the numberless stories of each life,
the millions of forgotten ancestors who preceded us,
the untold acts of kindness which occur
each day, we humble ourselves...
and treasure silence.

Silence

We ask that you will help us to save ourselves by forgetting ourselves.
In every experience and thought,
bring us to the certain knowledge
that we are children of your Infinite Holy Mystery.

And then, Infinite Mystery, assist us to envision
life as an opportunity to share in the creation of
a caring environment, to open our mind's eye
to the knowledge that if we give love,
nothing in life nor in death, nor things to come,
no things past, can separate us from your unending
state of grace.

*Help us on this day to receive this grace, and to give it.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

"Like A Stream Gently Flowing" from *Two Canons*
Cathedral Choir

GYÖRGI LIGETI

Sermon

Loved into New Life

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Lux Aurumque"
Laude

ERIC WHITACRE

"Light, warm and heavy, pure like gold. They sing, and sing, and sing to the preciousness of new birth."

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Rev. Schiefelbein

Eternal Mystery,
you live and take on flesh among us,
in ways great and small
to set the captives free
to rise among the oppressed
to bring healing to the wounded places
to issue in an era
of rest and restoration
of connection
of joy
of justice.

On this day, we have felt your presence,
calling us once again into your never-ending flow of life.

And now, we offer our gratitude
for this sacred place...
and all the people who come from near and far,
to call it home.

*May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

"Travelling On..."

Rev. Lehman

In response to the light we have felt this morning,
join me in this litany for the journey.

Creator of the Stars
God of Epiphanies
You are the Great Star.
You have marked our paths with light
you have filled our skies with stars
naming each star
guiding it
until it shines in our hearts
awakening us to deeper seeing
new revelations
and brighter epiphanies.

O infinite Star Giver
we now ask for wisdom and courage
to follow these stars
as we look for your light, O God,
in this, our time and place.

*Be to us this day
and forever more,
O Creator of the Stars,
an unending Epiphany.
Amen and Amen!*

[mwiederkehr / adapt]

Choral Response

"Hark, I Hear The Harps Eternal"
Cathedral Choir

arr. ALICE PARKER & ROBERT SHAW

***Hymn for the Journey**

Imagining Stars

SERVANT SONG

When, at night, the stars shine on us light years from our tiny earth,
Songs and psalms provoke the questions of our fragile human worth.

These gigantic specks are burning, balls of fire, as at play;
Stars in billions share their light and thus create a Milky Way.

We still gaze in raw amazement, contemplating timeless space;
Numberless, the stars keep stories hidden from our human race.

Tiny holes in heaven's flooring letting light beyond shine through;
Stars invite us to imagine what it is we cannot view.

Myst'ry strides across the canvas of the picture we might paint;
Sacredness is grandly present; let us praise without restraint. (GStuart)

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Allegro in G Major (Georg Rathgeber)

Inside The Music

"Most of the music for Stanley Kubrick's *"2001: A Space Odyssey"* comes from already written works by the Hungarian composer György Ligeti. During his lifetime, Western composers spent a lot of their energy challenging the tonal system that has organized music for hundreds of years. Ligeti and a cadre of Eastern European composers did this through density, expanded chromaticism, and rhythmic micropolyphony. This kind of writing resulted in a wash of scintillating sound alive with energy that is hard for the ear to pin down. It's electric music, perfect for Kubrick's image of space as charged emptiness. To create this sound, Ligeti's choral music calls for far more voices than we have, and is more difficult than our one rehearsal a week can manage. His *Two Canons* is one of the few pieces that he wrote for voice that doesn't require large forces. Although much easier for the ears to discern, Ligeti still uses the same tools of chromaticism, density, and rhythmic polyphony in the first of the two canons that we'll sing today. Through the use of implied modalism derived from distinct chromatic choices, he creates a sonic landscape that begins to escape tonality. By layering certain chromatic intervals as each line of the canon appears, he invites areas of harmonic density. The subtle rhythmic counterpoint of each line yields the moment-to-moment shimmer that micropolyphony brings. The text, "Like a stream gently flowing, dreaming dreams as I am going, that is how I'd like to live; so peacefully I'd flow," nestles happily into this texture. L.A.'s Eric Whitacre came into quick fame during the beginning of a post-minimalism craze that I affectionately call California Choral Pop. In effect, the lines between classical minimalism and popular music blurred in such a way that choral singers finally got what their ears had been craving throughout the 1990's rise of World Music: simplicity and idiomatic harmonic motion. Whitacre's success in this realm bears a connection to the extended harmonic reaches that Ligeti created. Though Whitacre never leans into the wash, he thrives on chords with enough added notes to create a wash-like vibe. Most of these chords can be found in the popular music that existed as he began his career as well. His particular approach, though, brings these harmonies forward, creating a signature sound akin to falling gently into a warm, candlelit bath. The ease of his paired-down use of text adds to this effect. In *"Lux Aurumque"* we hear "light" (lux) over and over again, followed by other repeated words. Ligeti's wash effect arrives, in part, with much less effort. If Ligeti is well known for the ways in which he punctured holes in our understanding of tonality and gave us a chance to listen through the light that seeped through, Whitacre owes his popularity to how he paints with light. The result of each composer is music that feels good to get lost in. Light does show us things, yes, but it also can also overwhelm our senses, freeing us into the possibilities of newness as we welcome what we have yet to understand. As I ponder the world we live in today, the promise of newness discovered through my senses feels increasingly delightful: an essential affirmation of self in a time when we all seem to be under pressure." ~ Dr. David Harris